

1 and 2 Peter

A Commentary on the Two Letters of the Apostle Peter

Joshua M. Haub

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1 and 2 Peter: A Commentary on the Two Letters the Apostle Peter

Joshua M. Haub
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*To those who reside as aliens, and to those who have received the same
kind of faith as ours.*

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1. Authorship

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Preface

1 and 2 Peter are some of the riches letters in the New Testament. However, it seems to me that both letters have been unintentionally degraded to “books of popular quotations” rather than two letters with specific agendas. Many cite the “Tested by Fire” motif in 1 Peter 1:7; large sections of chapter 2, such as the “Stone” motif and Christian realities (2:4-10), excellent attitude (2:11-12), submission (2:13-20) which climax in Jesus’ attitude (2:21-25); husbands and wives (3:1-7); apologetics (3:15); baptism (3:18-22); suffering (4:12-19); anxiety (5:7); and Satan as a lion (5:8-9). While these are all pieces of the puzzle of 1 Peter, simply quoting these sections without diving into 1 Peter does them a disservice. 1 Peter was not written to be cherry picked but to be read in its own context.

The same goes for 2 Peter. Often it is quoted for its sections on the Transfiguration (1:16-18); prophecy (1:20-21); false teaching (chapter 2); falling away (2:21-22); the second coming of Jesus (3:3-15a); and perhaps the most quoted section of the letter, the reference to Paul and his work which is equated with “Scripture” (3:15b-16). Like 1 Peter, 2 Peter has an audience and a *specific* message. These two letters are *letters*, after all, not divine motivation quotebooks meant for motivational speeches.

It seems to me that since 1 and 2 Peter are quoted so often, a detailed analysis of both has gone by the waste side. Many feel that they understand the letters well, and perhaps they do. However, I believe a comprehensive commentary on both letters would do much good for both the reader and I.

My hope is that by writing this commentary, you will grow in your knowledge and understanding of these two letters. Any and all errors found within are my own. May God be glorified in this work.

To Him Be the Glory,
Joshua M. Haub

About the Author

Joshua M. Haub was born and raised in Columbus, Indiana, and worshiped with the Lakeview church. He is currently a student at Florida College in Temple Terrace, Florida, studying Communication and Biblical Studies. He is an evangelist at the Lake Gibson church in Lakeland, Florida. He has been teaching the gospel for 5 years, including working with Ryan Boyer in Ellisville, Missouri, during the summer of 2024; working in Harrisburg, Pennsylvania, during the summer of 2025 with Scott Smelser and Stephen Rouse; and working with Andy Cantrell and Caleb Daniels in New Hope, Minnesota, during the summer of 2026. He can be reached at haubfam2@gmail.com

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Introduction to 1 Peter

“Peter, an apostle”

Text

External Evidence

Text

Internal Evidence

Text

Excursus

*The Communication of 1 and 2 Peter: How Different Are They?**

Over time, the authorship claims of several New Testament books have come into question. Of all the letters attributed to Paul, only seven are considered by some scholars to be genuine. 1 and 2 Peter are among the other “questioned” letters. Who wrote these two letters? Did one person write both or was it two separate individuals? Both are attributed to Peter, but did he pen them, have them penned, or do they simply hold his authority? Richard Bauckham writes, “It can safely be said that if 1 and 2 Peter had been anonymous documents, no one would have thought of attributing them to a single author” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 145). But is Bauckham correct? While the question of authorship cannot be solved on the basis of the way both letters communicate, these two letters can be shown to be deeply connected in important ways which suggests they may be from a single source.

The Internal Similarities, Differences, and Connections

I. First Peter

Joseph Mayor notes that “the style of 1 P. is clearer and simpler than that of 2 P., but there is not that chasm between them which some would try to make out” (Mayor, 1907, p. civ). He continues, “As to the use of the article, they [1 and 2 Peter,] resemble one another more than any other book of the N.T.” (Mayor, 1907, civ). Mayor works through several more grammatical characteristics and notes that they are very similar to one another (Mayor, 1907, civ). Mayor does note, however, that 2 Peter is much more ambiguous and difficult than 1 Peter. Mayor

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concludes by stating, “On the whole I should say that the difference of style is less marked than the difference in vocabulary, and that again less marked than the difference in matter, while above all stands the great difference in thought, feeling, and character, in one word of personality” (Mayor, 1907, cv).

William Dalton shows how 1 and 2 Peter are connected by examining how 2 Peter interprets 1 Peter 3:19 and 4:6. Before he discusses those passages, Dalton convincingly shows “great similarity in ideas and structure between 1 Pet 3,13-4:11 and 2 Pet 2,1-3,18” (Dalton, 1979, p. 551). Then, he turns to 1 Peter 3:19 and 4:6. Dalton notes that 1 Peter 3 is closely associated with 2 Peter 2 and that 1 Peter 3:19’s “spirits in prison” is parallel with “angels...committed...to pits of darkness” in 2 Peter 2:4. Dalton believes that 1 Peter 3:19-20 is a source for 2 Peter 2:4-5. 2 Peter 2:4-5 shows that 1 Peter 3:19-20 must be in reference to a proclamation to “sinful angels, a message that cannot be one of salvation” (Dalton, 1979, p. 553). Less convincing is his explanation of 1 Peter 4:6. He explains that this passage is connected with 2 Peter 3:7-12, stating that the “dead” in 1 Peter 4:6 are the Christians of 2 Peter, “who accept the reality of the Lord’s promise ‘of new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells’ (3,9,13)” (Dalton 1979, p. 554).

II. *Second Peter*

G. H. Boobyer discusses how 2 Peter is indebted to 1 Peter. Boobyer sees 2 Peter 3:1f as a reference to 1 Peter 1:10-2. He cites B. Weiss’ view that when it comes to general Christian teachings, “no document in the New Testament is so like 1 Peter as 2 Peter” (Boobyer, 1959, p. 35). Boobyer also cites Mayor’s list of parallels between the two letters: The Second Coming, Noah and seven persons being saved from the flood, μακροθυμία (“patience”) in 2 Peter 3:15 and 1 Peter 3:20, and “prophecy as a divinely inspired foretelling of Gospel events now announced by apostles” (Boobyer, 1959, p. 35). Also, note the exact reduplication of 1 Peter 1:2 and 2 Peter 2:2: “χαρίς ὑμῖν καὶ εἰρήνη

πληθυνθείη” (Nestle-Aland, 2012, 1 Peter 1:2), translated, “Grace to you and peace be multiplied” (Young’s Literal Translation, 1997, 1 Peter 1:2). Boobyer notes that πληθυνθείη “as the verb of a NT formula of greeting occurs only in 1 and 2 Peter and Jude” (Boobyer, 1959, p. 39). Boobyer insightfully comments that in the pursuit of establishing authorship for 2 Peter, many have either overstressed the resemblances with 1 Peter or exaggerated the disconnections depending on who they believe wrote 2 Peter (Boobyer, 1959, p. 36). He goes on to note how 1 Peter 1:3-9 and 2 Peter 1:3-11 seem to be closely connected. While this connection seems less satisfactory, the other data he provides is helpful in showing some of the similarities between the passages. Besides those already mentioned, he also sees connections between 1 Peter 1:10-2 and 2 Peter 1:12-21, and 1 Peter 5:1 with 2 Peter 1:16-8.

Donald Guthrie provides a helpful analysis of Boobyer’s work. In one section, Guthrie examines Boobyer’s evidence that 2 Peter is literarily dependent on 1 Peter. Guthrie notes, “His [Boobyer’s] justification for maintaining a literary dependence is based on his acceptance of 2 Peter’s literary use of Jude” (Guthrie, 1990, p. 852). At this point, Guthrie presses, “his evidence here would equally well support the contention that the same author wrote both 1 and 2 Peter, for in that case we should expect the kind of parallels to which he refers” (Guthrie, 1990, p. 852). Then, he questions Boobyer’s view that 2 Peter is pseudepigrapha yet 2 Peter 1:12-3 overflows from 1 Peter 1:10-2. Guthrie asserts, “this could equally well have happened in the mind of one man through association of ideas, as in two minds with one drawing from another” (Guthrie, 1990, 852).

Richard Bauckham maintains that the two letters have different styles and vocabularies, which has been noted since Jerome (Bauckham, 1983, p. 143). Bauckham states that the most important differences in the two letters “are not those of grammar and style but thought, themes, theological terminology...” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 145). For more of Bauckham’s observations, see *The Greek of 1 and 2 Peter* below.

III. Conclusion

There are many similarities and difference between these two letters. Boobyer is correct that both sides of the authorship debate surrounding 2 Peter must examine the evidence honestly and not overstate their case. As can be seen, there are many similarities, differences, and connections between 1 and 2 Peter. It seems reasonable to state that these letters are correctly put side-by-side in the NT. At the very least, they share some of the same thoughts, subject matters, and other qualities mentioned above. But there are also many differences. As will be noted throughout the rest of this study, there are more similarities, differences, and connections that are important to note in understanding the authorship of these letters. Based on those stated so far, there does seem to be some sort of connection between these two letters.

The Greek of 1 and 2 Peter

I. First Peter

One of the most significant questions concerning 1 and 2 Peter is their different Greek styles and vocabulary. Often, the Greek of 1 Peter is deemed an “elevated style of Greek” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 125). Wayne Grudem rightly states, “The Greek may be said to be excellent, but to say it is a literary masterpiece is probably an overstatement” (Gruden, 2024, p. 7). The difference in the style of Greek of both letters is important but should be neither underplayed nor overstated. A balanced approach is necessary.

One of the most helpful works on the Greek of 1 Peter is Karen Jobes’ excursus in her commentary on 1 Peter. She evaluates the Greek of 1 Peter by using criteria of what would be usual Greek tendencies for a Semitic individual when writing Greek. These tendencies include things such as the way prepositions are used, the use of articles, and others, totaling 17 criterions. She notes that “of the fourteen criteria relevant to 1 Peter, nine clearly fall on the side of the scale showing Semitic influence” (Jobes, 2022, p. 329). This means that 1 Peter is not

written as someone whose first language was Greek would have. Instead, it seems to be written by a Semitic person (e.g., *possibly* a Jewish person). Although Jobes notes “the style of 1 Peter, with its long sentences and rhetorical elements, may suggest someone who has a greater proficiency in Greek than would be expected of a Galilean fisherman. Nevertheless, Semitic interference is indicated...” (Jobes, 2022, p. 331). Because of Silvanus’ mention of 1 Peter 5:12 as a possible scribe, Jobes examines 1 Thessalonians (another letter noting Silvanus). What Jobes found was that 1 Thessalonians and 1 Peter are very similar in their use of Greek, both leaning toward Semitic influence. Jobes concludes, “The major conclusion drawn from this study is that the extent of Semitic interference in the Greek of 1 Peter indicates an author whose first language was *not* Greek” (Jobes, 2022, p. 334, *italics added*).

Michael Green is also helpful in evaluating the Greek of 1 and 2 Peter. Like Williams, Green notes that the Greek of 1 Peter is “polished, cultured, dignified; it is among the best in the New Testament” while 2 Peter is “grandiose...like baroque art, almost vulgar in its pretentiousness and effusiveness” (Green 1987, pp. 23-4). He suggests that 1 Peter may be the work of Silvanus (Green, 1987, p. 24). Green states that 1 and 2 Peter have as many remarkable stylistic resemblances as they do differences. Both letters have “strong Hebraisms and the striking habit of verbal repetition...these are features likely to have survived through the employment of different secretaries” (Green, 1987, p. 24). Green argues that while some of 1 Peter’s frequent words are missing in 2 Peter, “others are replaced with synonyms” (Green, 1987, p. 24). Green cites several scholars who argue the similarities between 1 and 2 Peter. First, Joseph Mayor who said, “There is not that chasm between 1 and 2 Peter which some would try to make out;” then, B. Weiss’ conclusion on a linguistic analysis, “the Second Epistle of Peter is allied to no New Testament writing more closely than to his First;” Holzmeister who “showed that 1 and 2 Peter are as close linguistically as 1 and 2 Corinthians;” A. E. Simms who

demonstrated that 1 and 2 Peter are as close “on the score of words used” as 1 and 2 Timothy (which have a unified author); and finally A. Q. Morton who wrote that “from cumulative sum analysis on the computer...1 and 2 Peter are indistinguishable linguistically” (Green, 1987, pp. 24-5).

Joseph Mayor lists 3 comprehensive charts of the Greek words that are used in both 1 and 2 Peter, only in 1 Peter, and only in 2 Peter. For words used in both letters, he totals 100. For words used only in 1 Peter, he notes a total of 369 (59 are *hapax legomena* (Greek words only found here in the NT)). For words used only in 2 Peter, he notes 230 (56 are *hapax legomena*). The final count is 100 words used in both and 599 that are not (Mayor, 1907, pp. lxix-lxxiv). Mayor concludes that “The Greek of the one is not by the same hand as the Greek of the other” (Mayor, 1907, lxxiv). However, as noted before, after a complete analysis of the Greek of both letters, Mayor notes that they are more similar than sometimes stated (see quote on previous paragraph).

II. Second Peter

Richard Bauckham states that 2 Peter “must be related to the ‘Asiatic’ style of Greek rhetoric which was coming into fashion in 2 Peter’s time...with its love of high-sounding expressions, florid and verbose language, and elaborate literary effects” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 137). Bauckham questions if there are any “genuine mms” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138). However he concludes that “a native Semitic speaker cannot be ruled out” but suggests another possibility is “a native Latin speaker” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138).

Bauckham also compares 2 Peter’s Greek with 1 Peter’s, much like Mayor. He states Holzmeister’s percentages: “38.6 percent [of words used in 2 Peter] are common to 1 and 2 Peter, 61.4 percent peculiar to 2 Peter, while...the words used in 1 Peter...28.4 percent are common to 1 and 2 Peter, [and] 71.6 percent peculiar to 1 Peter” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 144). 1 and 2 Peter both have a large number of *hapax legomena*, showing that the author(s) had a wide vocabulary

(Bauckham, 1983, p. 144). Finally, Bauckham states that the common words in both letters are “mostly very common words” with only *ἀπόθεσις* being “used exclusively in 1 and 2 Peter among the NT writings” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 144). While he deems the following list “not very impressive,” he does share possible “characteristics” of words used in both letters: *ἀναστροφή*, *ἄσπιλος*, *ἀρετή*, and *φιλαδελφία* (Bauckham, 1983, p. 144). He also shows that the letters choose to use different words for the same idea. For the Second Coming of Christ, *παρουσία* is used in 2 Peter 1:16, 3:4, 3:12 and *ἀποκάλυψις* in 1 Peter 1:7, 1:13, 4:13 (and *φανεροῦν* in 5:4). Bauckham makes an important statement, “Of course, both letters are relatively short, are evidently directed to different issues and situations, and deal on the whole with different subjects.” However goes on to state “if 1 and 2 Peter had been anonymous documents, no one would have thought of attributing them to a single author” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 145).

Michael Green writes that 2 Peter has Aramaic thought behind it, footnoting Chaine who lists a host of Semitisms behind 2 Peter (Green, 1987, p. 27, footnote 28). The footnote continues, stating that G. Wohlenberg suggested that 2 Peter may originally have been in Aramaic and then translated into Greek (Green, 1987, p. 27, footnote 28). Green also wrote an article titled, “2 Peter Reconsidered,” in which he notes some of the Hebraisms in the letter. He lists “*φθοπῆ φθαρῆσονται, καταρῆς τέκνα*, and *τοὺς ὀπίσω σαρκὸς πορευομένους*” (Green, 1960, p. 11). He goes on to note that the form of Peter’s name in 1:1 may be “a genuine Hebraism used by Peter himself” (Green, 1960, p. 14). If it is not, Green suggests an alternative that it is “a brilliant archaism without parallel in the writings of the second century, including the whole corpus of pseudo-Petrine literature” (Green, 1960, p. 14).

III. Conclusion

The Greek of both letters is a complicated issue. However, at times there can be a temptation to overstate how different the Greek of these

two letters are. The Greek of both is clearly different, however Bauckham’s note that they are short letters to different groups in different situations is important. In both letters, there seems to be signs of a possible Semitic speaker or at least influence and an overlap of some Greek words. While it is unclear if both letters come from a common source, the different style and word choice does not outweigh the possibility that the author of the letters simply made choices based on the need of his audiences, resulting in completely different letters. While this result seems far from satisfying on its own, it may be the case if other evidence works to show a common author.

The Use of the OT

I. First Peter

Karen Jobes wrote the entry on “1 Peter” in D. A. Carson’s *Dictionary of the New Testament Use of the Old Testament* (2023). In it, she notes that 1 Peter primarily quotes from the Septuagint (“LXX” used for the first five books. “Old Greek” is used for the rest of the OT). Jobes notes two primary purposes for 1 Peter’s use of OT: “to explain that Jesus was the Messiah, who, it was predicted, would suffer and die (prophetic interpretation)” and “to explain how Christian believers are to live out their new live in Christ” (Jobes, 2023, p. 594). Jobes notes that there are two OT sections that are prominent in 1 Peter: Psalm 34 (OG) and Isaiah, along with many other connections. See Table 1.

Table 1
1 Peter and the OT: Quotations, Citations, Allusions, and Influence

1 Peter	Exodus	Leviticus	Psalms	Proverbs	Isaiah	Hosea	Other
1:1							Israelite Exile
1:2	24:3-8						
1:3			34:2 (33:2 OG)				

1:6		33:20 (OG)	
1:16	19:2		
1:17		33:5, 8 (OG)	
1:18		33:23 (OG)	
1:24- 5			40:6-8
2:3		33:1ff (OG); 33:9 (OG)	
2:4-8		118:22 (117:22 OG)	8:14, 28:16 (OG)
2:6		33:6 (OG)	28:16 (OG)
2:7		117:22 (OG)	
2:8			8:14
2:9	19:5-6 (LXX)		43:4, 20-1 (OG)
2:10			2:23 (2:25 OG)
2:11		33:5 (OG)	
2:17		33: 10, 12 (OG)	
2:18- 3:7			53:1ff
2:22			53:9 (OG)
2:23			53:7
2:24			53:4-5 (OG)

2:25		53:6 (OG)	
3:6			Abraham and Sarah (cf. Gen 18:22 LXX)
3:10- 2	33:12-7 (OG)		
3:12	33:18 (OG)		
3:14- 5		8:12-3 (OG)	
3:20- 1			Noah and Flood
4:8	10:12?		
4:14		11:2	
4:18	11:31 (OG)		
5:5	3:34 (OG)		
5:13			Israelite Exile

Information from Jobes (2023, p. 594-600).

Note: 4:8 and Proverbs 10:12 is marked with a “?” due to Jobes’ comment that this is probably not a quotation but rather Peter utilizing a “proverbial use” of the proverb “that was in circulation” at that time (Jobes, 2023, p. 597).

Jobes notes that 1 Peter’s use of the OT shows that he viewed the OT as authoritative and being fulfilled in Jesus (Jobes, 2023, p. 599). She also observes that the use of OT in this letter “contribute[s] specific content to Peter’s thought, some of it distinctive and unique within the NT” (Jobes, 2023, p. 599). She makes two lists: “Contributions to Christology” (9 listed) and “Instructions for Christian life” (12 listed) (see Jobes, 2023, p. 599-600). Jobes concludes with stating that the use of OT in 1 Peter is meant to “orient its readers...to see themselves drawn by faith in Jesus Christ into the long and magnificent heritage of Israel” (Jobes, 2023, p. 600). Deeply connected

are the sections on Jesus (Christology) and one's new life in Jesus (paraenesis). Finally, in her commentary on 1 Peter, Jobes notes that 1 Peter is similar to Romans and Hebrews in OT reference frequency (Jobes, 2022, p. 46). Also, she mentions that at times 1 Peter quotes the LXX/OG exactly while other times it is slightly different forms of the text, possibly suggesting a different version was available to 1 Peter (Jobes, 2022, p. 47).

II. Second Peter

Matthew Harmon wrote the entry on "2 Peter and Jude" in D. A. Carson's *Dictionary of the New Testament Use of the Old Testament* (2023). For 2 Peter, Harmon notes that the letter seems to, on some level, know Second Temple Jewish texts and traditions and uses them "potentially in the way that... [2 Peter] interpret[s] OT texts" (Harmon, 2023, p. 412). Also, 2 Peter frequently refers to OT people and events without noting specific passages. Harmon states, "As a result, it can be difficult to determine the OT text form... [2 Peter] use[s]" (Harmon, 2023, p. 412). There are three main theological themes in 2 Peter: "the Word of God, God's judgment on his enemies and salvation of his people, and the return of Christ to consummate a new creation" (Harmon, 2023, p. 412). See Table 2.

Table 2
2 Peter and the OT: Quotations, Citations, Allusions, and Influence

2 Peter	Genesis	Numbers	Psalms	Proverbs	Isaiah	Habakkuk	Malachi	Other
1:11?								<i>Daniel 7:27</i> (OG)? <i>Daniel 7:14?</i>
1:17	22:2, 12, 16		2:7; 8:5 (8:6 OG)?	42:1				
1:19		24:17-9	19:8; 37:6; 46:5; 130:6; 119:105, 130		9:2		4:2	Luke 1:78-9; <i>Song of Songs</i> 2:17?
2:2					52:5 (OG)			

persons and events that even a name or a brief phrase is enough to evoke the entire OT context of that reference” (Harmon, 2023, p. 415). It seems to Harmon that 2 Peter does not so much directly quote (or cite) the OT as much as it does allude to and (potentially) echo it. Harmon notes that the main way that 2 Peter uses the OT is by blending “analogies and typology, with the line between those categories not always clear” (Harmon, 2023, p. 415). 2 Peter uses “stock-in-trade language from the OT” to describe false teachers (Harmon, 2023, p. 415).

Bauckham also lists possible allusions to the OT in his commentary on 2 Peter. See Table 2 above. He notes that “unlike Jude, 2 Peter’s allusions are habitually to the LXX” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138). Bauckham then lists 2 Peter passages that “correspond to the language of the LXX” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138), including: “1:11 (Dan 7:27 0, LXX); 1:17 (Ps 8:6); 1:19 (Num 24:17); 2:2 (Isa 52:5); 2:5 (Gen 6:17); 2:6 (Gen 19:29); 3:12 (Isa 34:4); 3:13 (Isa 65:17). In the following cases the allusion is certainly not to the LXX version: 1:19 (Cant 2:17); 2:22 (Prov 26:11); 3:9, 12–14 (Hab 2:3); 3:12 (Isa 60:22), but in all except the first of these cases the author has probably taken the allusion from an intermediate source” (p. 138). These are found in Table 2 above.

Bauckham goes on to state that because of 2 Peter’s familiarity with the LXX/OG, the phrases in the letter that are typical in the LXX/OG should be listed: “πορεύεσθαι ὀπίσω, 2:10; ἐπ’ ἐσχάτων τῶν ἡμέρων, 3:3; ποῦ ἐστίν; 3:4” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138). He also affirms that the author may be familiar with “extrabiblical Jewish haggadic traditions (2:4-5, 7-8, 15-16)” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138).

III. Conclusion

1 and 2 Peter are both full of OT references. There are a few overlapping OT references in these two letters. The clearest is Noah and

the Flood (1 Peter 3:20-1 and 2 Peter 3:6). Both letters also have a (distant) reference to Isaiah 43 (1 Peter 2:9 with Isaiah 43:3, 20-1 (OG) and 2 Peter 3:13 with Isaiah 43:16-21). Another (distant) reference may be found in Israelite Exile in 1 Peter 5:13 with Daniel and 2 Peter 1:11, 17 with Daniel 7:14 and 7:27 (OG), but the 2 Peter reference is questioned by Bauckham (see above). There is also a connection in Genesis 18-9 (LXX) (1 Peter 2:9 with Genesis 19:5-6 and 2 Peter 2:6-9 with Genesis 19:29). In addition to these connections, both books cite from three of the same OT books: Psalms, Proverbs, and Isaiah. Outside of Isaiah 43, these books share no OT reference in these respective books. However, passages in Psalms and Isaiah that are referenced are near one another (see Tables 1-2 above).

Of interest is 1 and 2 Peter's commitment to the LXX/OG version of the OT. As stated above, Jobes and Bauckham note in their respective works that 1 and 2 Peter use this translation the majority of the time. The use of a single translation for most of the references in these letters shows another layer of similarity between these two letters. However, the LXX/OG is a common translation in the New Testament, so the connection here must not be pressed too far. If Jobes is correct that the readers of 1 Peter are supposed to see themselves as joining Israel's heritage found in the OT, then the readers of 2 Peter have already done that, having become, in Harmon's words, "so familiar with those OT persons and events that even a name or a brief phrase is enough to evoke the entire OT context of that reference" (Harmon, 2023, p. 415).

The Gospels in 1 and 2 Peter

I. First Peter

1 Peter has several connections with the Gospels and their traditions. Before exploring them, there are a few things about the Gospels that must be noted. When a connection is identified between the Gospels and another writing, the key question becomes whether the author of the

other writing (here, 1 Peter) knew what Jesus *said* or only what the Gospel author *wrote*. Some scholars do not believe the words of Jesus in the Gospels are his actual words, but simply what he either was believed to have said or what his teachings meant. This is called *ipsissima verba* (“the very words”) and *ipsissima vox* (“the very voice”). Therefore, the question is often raised whether the connections in 1 Peter are to the written Gospels, their traditions, or to Jesus himself.

Robert Gundry wrote an extensive article on the connections between 1 Peter and the Gospels. His connections are noted in Table 3 (see below). Of all the *verba Christi* (Jesus’ words) in 1 Peter, “only two are not directly related to gospel contexts in which the Apostle Peter plays a prominent part or would have had a special interest” (Gundry, 1966, p. 348). The two places are 1 Peter 1:8 with John 20:29 and 1 Peter 1:23-2:1 with John 3:3, 7. Gundry also qualifies that there are certain teachings in 1 Peter that could connect back to the Sermon on the Mount but because they are also taught in other NT epistles, they cannot be used to show a dependence on the Gospels and Jesus. However, the connections are still noted in Table 3 below.

I do not believe that all of the connections Gundry makes are necessarily accurate. It seems that one could make connections just about anywhere if one tries. Even Gundry himself says, “Several of the Dominical sayings reviewed... may be questioned” (Gundry, 1966, p. 348). However, his work shows that there are connections with the Gospels and Jesus’ teachings which cannot be overlooked. The presence of teachings from Jesus in 1 Peter which Peter himself was present for are significant. Gundry writes, “It is unthinkable that a pious forger who knew the gospel tradition cleverly inserted very allusive references to *verba Christi* from only those parts which Peter would most likely have remembered” (Gundry, 1966, p. 348). The attributed author, then, includes material that he himself was present to hear.

Table 3
1 Peter and the Gospels: Connections, Allusions, and Influence

1 Peter	Matthew	Mark	Luke	John
1:3				3:3, 7
1:4			12:33	
1:6	5:10ff			
1:8				20:29
1:10-2			24:25f	
1:13		8:3	12:32, 35, 45	
1:21				14:1, 6
1:22				8:34f, 15:12
1:23				3:3, 7
2:1				3:3, 7
2:4, 7	16:18; 21:42	7:10		
2:9	5:16			
2:12	5:16			
2:13-7	17:26f			
2:18ff	5:10ff		6:27ff	
2:19f			6:32-5	
2:24				10:2-18
2:25				10:11, 14
3:8				13:5ff
3:14	5:10			
4:7		8:3; 14:32- 42	21:31, 34, 36	
4:8				8:34f, 15:12
4:13f	5:10ff			
4:19			23:46	
5:2			12:32	10:11, 14; 21:15-7 8:4f
5:3				
5:3-5	20:25-8	10:42-5	22:25-30	
5:4				10:11, 14
5:8f	26:40	8:3; 14:38	22:31f	

Information from Gundry (1966, p. 337-348).

Ernest Best, however, responded to Gundry (and others). He walks through many of the alleged connections and notes that the only connections that seem correct are blocks of texts in Luke 6 and 12 along with two isolated sayings: Matt 5:16 and Mark 10:45 (and possibly Matt 5:10).

Best makes an important observation: “knowledge of the gospel tradition on the part of any author in the N.T. does not logically imply that he was present when that part of the gospel tradition was spoken by Jesus” (Best, 1970, p. 95). Paul, for example, knows of Jesus’ teachings but that does not mean he was necessarily with Jesus when he taught them.

It seems to me, however, that while Best is helpful in balancing the possible connections, he is sometimes unfair in his use of criteria, as Gundry notes concerning 1 Clement (see below). In one part of the article, Best states if Mark 10:45 was a true saying of Jesus, then 1 Peter 1:18 would be dependent on it, but since Titus 2:14 is closer to Mark than 1 Peter is, “We cannot conclude that the author of 1 Peter was present when the logion was spoken without suggesting that the author of Titus was also present” (Best, 1970, p. 99-100). Here, Best overlooked that the author of Titus does not claim to be an eye-witness as 1 Peter does (by implication of its alleged author). Correctly, however, Best concludes that Mark 10:45 as a saying which 1 Peter is connected.

Gundry responded to Best and pointed out issues with Best’s rebuttal. He states that “The standards by which allusions are judged genuine drop in the comparisons between *1 Clement* and Lk 6” (Gundry, 1970, p. 232). He also maintains that his thesis was not that Peter used the Gospels but that “he used traditions *deriving from his own memory* and independently written by others in the gospels” (Gundry, 1970, p. 221, italics added). While Gundry may draw too many connections, Best appears to recognize too few. The evidence is best understood as lying somewhere between these two positions.

Thomas Lea gives an interesting case study of one instance of a possible connection between 1 Peter and the Gospels. Assuming Petrine authorship, he examines the use of what he calls “stone theology.” In 1 Peter 2:4-8, Peter uses three different words for “stone” (λίθος, πέτρα, and ἀκρογωνιαίον). Lea notes “No other part of Scripture makes such extensive reference to stone and rock in relation to Jesus Christ as does this brief portion of 1 Peter” (Lea, 1980, p. 97). In this passage, Peter uses Psalm 118:22-3, Isaiah 8:14, and Isaiah 28:16. Lea suggests that Peter learned to use these passages from his time with Jesus, noting that Jesus himself used Psalm 118:22 in Matthew 21:42 (parallel: Mark 12:10-1 and Luke 20:17). Lea states, “In each reference to the Old Testament there is a close conformity to the text of the Septuagint in the portion quoted, and this distinctive quality is true also of the reference to the Psalm appearing in 1 Peter 2:7” (Lea, 1980, 98). Lea suggests that Peter would have been at this event to hear Jesus quote this Psalm. Interestingly, Peter also quotes the Psalm in Acts 4:11. Additionally, there is a possibility that Luke 20:18, directly following Jesus’ use of Psalm 118, could have influenced Peter’s mind to think of Isaiah 8:14-5 (Lea, 1980, p. 99). This to me, however, seems less likely.

Lea, importantly, acknowledges that there are other sources which use “stone theology,” such as Paul (see Romans 9:33 and Ephesians 2:20). Lea, therefore, says that it is possible Peter was “influenced by these sources in addition to Jesus, or it is possible that all three may have their usage of stone theology traced to a common source” (Lea, 1980, p. 100). Finally, Lea notes that because of Peter’s nickname (“Πέτρος”) he would have been interested in “stone” and “rock” motifs from Jesus. All this points Lea to see Jesus as a (likely) source for Peter’s understanding of these OT passages, especially Psalm 118.

II. *Second Peter*

Richard Bauckham notes four allusions (and other possible ones) to the Gospels in 2 Peter. See Table 4.

Table 4***2 Peter and the Gospels: Connections, Allusions, and Influence***

2 Peter	Matthew	Mark	Luke	John
1:14				21:18
1:16-18	Closest (deemed an independent tradition); 16:28?	9:1?		
2:9	6:13?			
2:20	12:45		11:26	
2:21		9:42? 14:21?		
3:4		9:1 (parallel: 13:30)?		
3:10	24:43		12:39 (cf. 1 Thess 5:2)	

Information from Bauckham (1983, p. 148).

Note: Passages marked with a “?” Bauckham states are possible but not definite allusions and/or echoes.

Bauckham states the author of 2 Peter seems to know Gospel tradition independent of the Gospels we use. He continues on to say that of the four we use, Matthew is the most likely source.

Boobyer and Schreiner give even more possible allusions in their respective works. Boobyer notes the use of the word *ἐξοδος* in 1:15, which is the same word used in Luke 9:31 for Jesus’ departure (Boobyer, 1959, p. 45). Schreiner connects “honor and glory” (1:17) with the Transfiguration, suggesting that Jesus’ face was glorious (Luke 9:29, 32) and God’s message was honorable (Matt 17:5, Mark 9:7, and Luke 9:35) (Schreiner, 2003, 315).

III. Conclusion

Thanks to the work of these scholars, it seems that both epistles use either Gospels traditions or the Gospels more directly. Interestingly,

both books have possible allusions from all four Gospels, showing at the very least a diverse understanding of the life and teachings of Jesus, although some are heavily disputed, as Best showed. Schreiner is helpful here, commenting that when evaluating 2 Peter and the Gospels, one must remember that if he was an eye-witness, he was recalling events from memory and not necessarily from the four written Gospels, but does suggest Peter may have relied on Matthew (Schreiner, 2003, 315-6).

Notably, Mayor suggests that 1 Peter is written exactly how one would expect the apostle Peter to have written (Mayor, 1907, cxiii). He does not believe this holds true for 2 Peter. However, it seems that Mark 9:9 sheds light on 2 Peter 1:16-8. Jesus instructed Peter (and others) to not share their experience on the mountain until after his resurrection. Whether one believes this is historical or a literary device, it is interesting that the Transfiguration is not again mentioned in the NT until 2 Peter, a letter said to have been written by an eye-witness of the event. Either a clever reader of Mark saw the note and decided to use it as he embodied Peter, or Peter himself understood that now, years after Jesus' resurrection, it was appropriate for him to discuss such a powerful event in his life. The underlying connections to the Gospels in these two letters give support to an author well-developed in Jesus' teachings.

Paul in 1 and 2 Peter

I. First Peter

Travis Williams writes that there has been debate over if 1 Peter was directly influenced by Pauline letters (like Romans and Ephesians). According to Williams, the current consensus is that the similarities between 1 Peter and Pauline literature are because of “the use of common tradition in early Christianity” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 65). Williams and Horrell, therefore, believe that 1 Peter was not a “quasi-Pauline document, standing firmly in Pauline tradition”

(Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 65) but rather uses early Christian traditions. Williams continues, stating some of the similarities, differences, and connections between 1 Peter and Paul's letters. Firstly, the opening and closing of 1 Peter seem to follow Paul's pattern (however, there are differences). Such similarities are ἀπόστολος Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ ("Apostle of Jesus Christ," 1:1) and χάρις ὑμῖν καὶ εἰρήνη ("Grace to you and peace," 1:2). Williams notes that the following word in 1:2, "πληθυνθείη," is "unknown in the Pauline letters but found...in Jewish epistolary tradition...and in the greetings of Jude, 2 *Peter*, and 1 Clement" (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 67, italics added). Next, Williams notes the similarities between 1 Peter 1:3-9 and Eph 1:3-14. He also points out "the most striking link with Paul is the exhortation ἀσπάσασθε ἀλλήλους ἐν φιλήματι ἀγάπης ([*"Greet one another with a kiss of love,"*] 1 Pet 5:14), which is paralleled only, and almost precisely, in Paul (Rom 16:16; 1 Cor 16:20; 2 Cor 13:12; 1 Thess 5:26)" (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 69). He goes further, "There is a distinction between Paul's holy kiss...and 1 Peter's kiss of love...though this is hardly enough to establish the independence...of 1 Peter from Paul" (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 69). Williams concludes that there is likely "some kind of Pauline influence on 1 Peter" (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 69). Then, Williams comments that "the particular formulation of paraenetical tradition found in 1 Peter seems to reflect Pauline influence" with Romans being a likely sort of source for 1 Peter's author (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 70). Williams footnotes a rebuttal against those who would reject any form of Pauline influence on 1 Peter and state that the only connection between them is common tradition. Williams challenges those who claim no literary relationship between Romans and 1 Peter, stating that if both Romans and the author of 1 Peter were in the same place at the same time, why not see Romans to be a source for 1 Peter? Additionally, Williams sees a connection between 1 Peter 2:13-7 and Romans 13:1-7, noting "1 Peter's household-code teaching and exhortations about submission to the governing authorities seem to

reflect the influence of Pauline tradition” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 71-2). There are also several parallels between the phrasing and terminology in both 1 Peter and Pauline literature such as ἐν Χριστῷ (1 Peter 3:16; 5:10, 14), which “occurs...[outside Paul’s letters] in the NT only in 1 Peter” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 72). For more, see Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 72. In conclusion, Williams states that “1 Peter shows clear signs of awareness of and dependence upon Pauline language and tradition” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 73).

II. Second Peter

Richard Bauckham states that 2 Peter knew at least some of Paul’s letters because 2 Peter 3:15 calls them “Scripture” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 147). However, he goes on to say that “there is little sign of Pauline influence in 2 Peter” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 147). Bauckham includes Lindemann’s conclusion that “2 Peter is entirely uninfluenced by Pauline theology and contains no allusion to the Pauline letters” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 147). Bauckham gives the only allusions he sees as even possible: 2 Peter 2:19 with Romans 8:21 (cf. 6:16; 7:5), 2 Peter 3:15 with Romans 12:3 (cf. 15:15), and 2 Peter 3:10 with 1 Thessalonians 5:2. He says, “They are far from certain” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 147). It may be that 2 Peter did not see Paul’s work as relevant to his own, but this may be unsatisfactory as a complete explanation (Bauckham, 1983, p. 148). Bauckham offers another possibility: “the author’s theological thinking and terminology were formed before he had much contact with Pauline theology, and that a collection of Paul’s letters was only just coming into use at the time when he wrote” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 148).

III. Conclusion

1 and 2 Peter’s relationship with Paul are clearly different. 1 Peter seems to be influenced by Paul, either by common tradition or Paul himself or both. There are several components of 1 Peter that remind

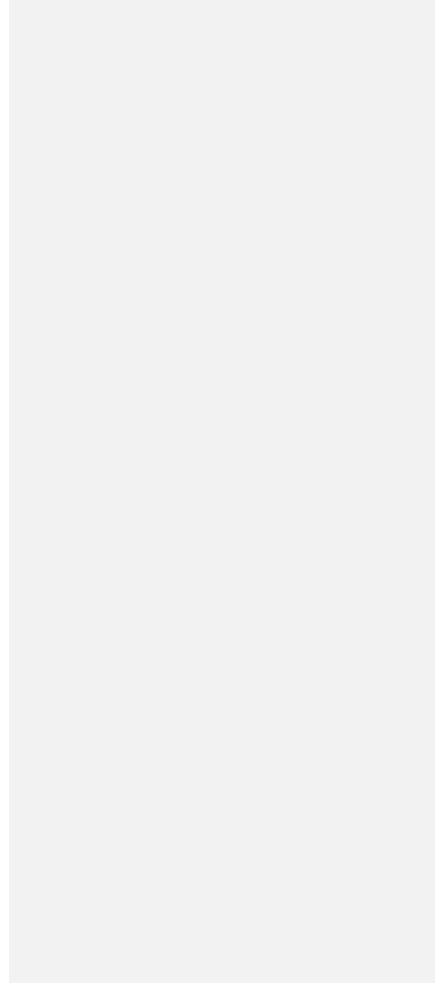
the reader of Paul. The same cannot be said about 2 Peter. Interestingly, however, while 1 Peter seems influenced by Paul, it is 2 Peter that refers to him directly. It may be that despite Bauckham (and Lindemann) seeing it as very unsatisfactory, the reason for a lack of Pauline influence on 2 Peter is due to 2 Peter's focus—simply because he could have used Paul does not by necessity mean he needed to. As Bauckham noted as a possible answer: 2 Peter could have developed his own respective theological thinking and terminology before he read much of Paul's work. If Petrine authorship is accepted, then this possibility may be plausible. However, when it comes to 1 and 2 Peter and Paul, it seems that these letters are quite different in their relationship to him.

Analysis and Conclusion

From a careful study of the material presented here, these two letters seem to be closer aligned than Bauckham suggests (see Bauckham, 1983, p. 145). While they are by no means identical to one another in their presentation, style, vocabulary, or the like, they do share important similarities, such as the Semitic nature of both letters, use of OT and its characters and events, connection to the Gospels (both to Jesus' teachings and events involving Peter), and other general similarities discussed above.

While the question of joint authorship of these two letters cannot be finalized based solely on a literary analysis, it can be shown that these books are deeply connected in some important ways, which may lead the way to a "single-author" conclusion. There is more work to be done on the question of Petrine authorship, but these specific pieces of evidence demonstrate that the relationship between the two letters is defined by more than their differences. Boobyer is correct: "The resemblances and differences between these writings seem to have been examined mainly...as an aspect...of the authorship [question] of 2 Peter. This may have led those concerned to establish a common authorship...to overstress the resemblances, whilst those convinced that the second was not by the same hand...could have exaggerated the disconnectedness" (Boobyer, 1959, p. 36). When the similarities and

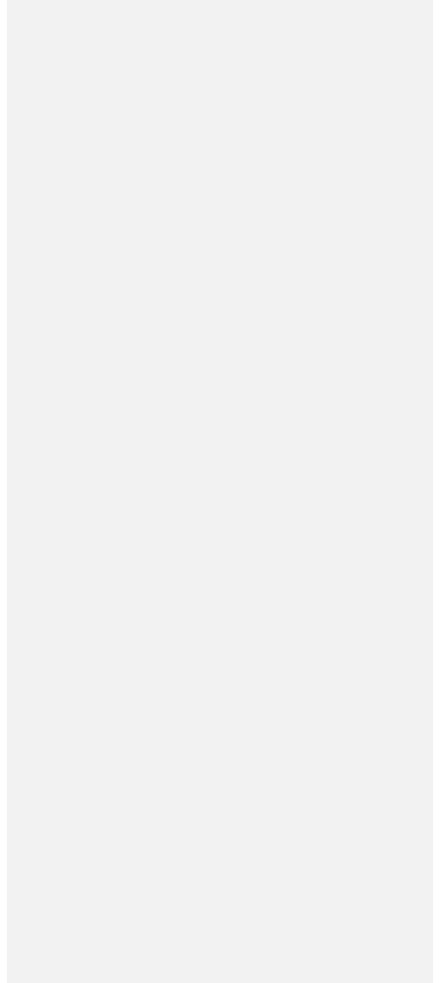
differences are evaluated honestly, there is a strong reason to take the opening words of these letters at face value: “Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ.”



1 Peter

1:1-

Text



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Introduction to 2 Peter

“Simon Peter, a bond-servant and apostle”

1. Authorship

The letter begins with a claim of authorship: “Simon Peter.” In some manuscripts, the name is “Simeon Peter.”¹ There has been much debate over whether Peter wrote it, dictated it, gave approval of it, had someone else finish it, and the like.² It seems to me that the best answer is that Peter wrote it. I do not know if he wrote it himself or used a secretary (amanuensis), but the letter’s introduction follows the typical NT epistle: a claim who it is from and greeting.

The significance of the claim that Peter wrote this letter should not be lost on us. This letter claims to have apostolic authority, which was a key factor in the early church’s evaluation of NT letters.³ For those who reject Petrine authorship and claim this was a pseudepigraphal work (that is, written by someone else but claimed it was by Peter), some have opted to say that 2 Peter should be *removed* from the NT canon.⁴ This is an alarming claim. If Peter did not write it, why is it in our NT? Should it be? This raises a host of questions. The importance of understanding the authorship of 2 Peter is essential. So, did Peter write this letter or not?

¹ According to H. A. G. Houghton, “Simon” is found in “B³⁷², 03, 044, 5, 81, etc.” while “Simeon” is found in “01, 02, 025, 33, 307, etc.” See H. A. G. Houghton, *A Textual Commentary on the Greek New Testament: A Companion to the Sixth Edition of the United Bible Societies’ Greek New Testament* (Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 2025), 349. So, while “Simon” is found in the oldest extant manuscript (B³) is dated to 3rd-4th century), codices 01 and 02 (“Simeon”) are dated to a similar time (01 = 4th century; 02 = 5th century). Houghton notes that it may be more likely that the Hebrew form of Peter’s name (“Simeon”) would have been corrected to the more common form: “Simon.” Thus the UBS6 has “Simeon” instead of “Simon.” For more on “Simeon” and its significance, see p. 15 and discussion below on the Internal Evidence for Petrine authorship.

² For some of these, see Excursus: “Who Wrote Second Peter?” below.

³ See footnote 7 on p. 38.

⁴ See footnote 4 on p. 36.

External Evidence

See Excursus below (page 38). I have written a previous paper on this issue and have adapted it for this commentary.

Internal Evidence

Text

Excursus

*Who Wrote Second Peter? Assessing Its Authorship, Dating, and Early Reception**

The most controversial book within the NT canon is, without a doubt, 2 Peter. It has often been debated by scholars as to whether it was written by Peter or by someone either pretending to be him or using his authority (pseudepigrapha).¹ Even scholars such as Bruce Metzger doubted Peter wrote this epistle.² If Peter did not write it, then one might ask why it was included in the NT canon.³ Did the Church Fathers make a mistake adding it to the canon?⁴ In this paper, it is my objective to show that while the argument for Petrine authority is not

* Originally written as a paper, Joshua M. Haub, "Who Wrote Second Peter? Assessing Its Authorship, Dating, and Early Reception." (unpublished paper, Florida College, 2026), 1-9. It has been adapted for this commentary. For paper edition, see <https://joshuahaub.com/peter/#/second-peter-authorship>.

¹ I use the word "pretending" in substitute for "forger," which is what a pseudepigrapher is, so B. Ehrman, as noted in M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," *JETS* 42, no. 4 (December 1999): 645-71 (648). Ehrman states "'Indeed, despite its common occurrence, forgery was almost universally condemned by ancient authors.'" It may be said, then, that forgery was condemned in the early centuries and perhaps can be classified as a form of lying.

The argument that a pseudepigrapher used Peter's name in order to write under Peter's authority is stated by T. Schreiner as the view of most scholars, see T. Schreiner, *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, vol. 37 of *The New American Commentary* (Nashville: Broadman & Holman Publishers, 2003), 255.

² Stated by B. Ehrman in his blog, B. Ehrman, "A Writing of Peter that *Barely* Got Into the New Testament," *The Bart Ehrman Blog*, August, 2022, <https://ehrmanblog.org/a-writing-of-peter-that-barely-got-into-the-new-testament/>.

³ This question is anticipated in K. Aland, "The Problem of Anonymity and Pseudonymity in Christian Literature of the First Two Centuries," *JTS* n.s. 12, no. 1 (April 1961): 39-49. Aland seemingly suggests that the reason some writings in the NT (ones that he supposes are pseudepigrapha) are included in the canon is not because they *were* written by their supposed author but because the early Christians *believed* they were written by them. See p. 49.

⁴ So G. Klein and J. Dunn as noted in T. Schreiner, *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, vol. 37, 265. Schreiner writes, "[Klein] proceeds to say that it is unfortunate the letter was even included in the canon. Dunn remarks that some of the writings of Luther and Wesley are equal to, or even better than, what we find in 2 Peter." According to R. Wall in his work R. Wall, "The Canonical Function of 2 Peter," *NTS* 39, no. 4 (October 1993): 645-59, he states "A growing number of interpreters now read 2 Peter within the context of a wider body of pseudo-Petrine writings, all of which are deuteron-canonical and mostly heterodox." Thus, some modern critics treat 2 Peter's theology "in a manner similar to writings of the New Testament pseudepigrapha," 65. For a short discussion of some wishing to remove 2 Peter from the canon (or mark it as pseudepigrapha), see M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," 651-6.

without difficulties, it still seems that there is enough external evidence to suggest it is plausible that Peter *did* write 2 Peter and therefore should be part of the NT canon.

Importance of Authorship

To begin a discussion of 2 Peter, I must state why authorship matters for 2 Peter. Michael Kruger puts it succinctly: “There seems to be little dispute that apostolic authority was an essential criterion of canonicity for the early church.”⁵ The early church, therefore, accepted writings they believed came from those with apostolic authority, of which Peter was one.⁶ The writings which claimed apostolic authority, while not being from an apostle (and therefore were considered pseudepigrapha), were often rejected.⁷ This is the heart of the issue. If Peter did not write it, perhaps we ought to not accept it as Scripture!⁸

Now, let us turn to the dating of the letter. R. Bauckham, in his commentary on Jude and 2 Peter, notes several factors that help us estimate when 2 Peter was written.⁹ He identifies several connections, but I will point out two: (1) 2 Peter may have been an authoritative source for the *Apoc. Pet.* in the early second century, and (2) 2 Peter shares verbal similarities with the late first—and early second—century writings of *1 Clem.*, *2 Clem.*, and the *Shepherd of Hermas*.¹⁰ He goes on

⁵ M. Kruger, “The Authenticity of 2 Peter,” 646-7. He also footnotes: “Bruce M. Metzger (*The New Testament: Its Background, Growth and Content* [New York: Abingdon, 1965] 276) declares that ‘the chief criterion for acceptance of particular writings as sacred, authoritative, and worthy of being read in services of worship was apostolic authorship.’”

⁶ R. Bauckham disputes this claim in his work R. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, WBC 50 (Waco, TX: Word, 1983), 161-2, stating that the key in 2 Peter’s authorship for the early church was not the writer but the “claim to be a faithful mediator of the apostolic message.” Therefore, according to Bauckham, the message is more important than the author.

⁷ See M. Kruger, “The Authenticity of 2 Peter,” 647. It is here that Kruger notes Serapion (c. AD 180) and his rejection of the *Gospel According to Peter*. Serapion wrote, “We receive both Peter and the other apostles as Christ, but the writings which falsely bear their name (πseudεπίγραφα) [that is, pseudepigrapha] we reject.”

⁸ See footnotes 4, 6, and 7 for conflicting views.

⁹ For much of what follows, I am indebted to R. Bauckham and his work found in *Jude, 2 Peter*, WBC 50.

¹⁰ *Ibid.*, 149-50. Bauckham suggests these dates for these works: *Apoc. Pet.* (perhaps c. AD 110-40), *1 Clem.* (c. AD 96), *2 Clem.* (perhaps end of first century, beginning of the second), and

to say that all four of these works may have been written in close proximity, “perhaps no more than twenty years” apart.¹¹ Taking into account other evidence, such as his interpretation of 3:4, he suggests that the dating is probably “c. AD 80-90,” well after Peter’s death.¹²

Michael Kruger largely agrees with Bauckham on dating.¹³ Kruger turns to the early Church Fathers, noting that “Clement of Alexandria (c. 150-215)” wrote a now-lost commentary on 2 Peter.¹⁴ “Irenaeus (c. 130-200)” may have also known the epistle.¹⁵ Also, “Justin Martyr (c. 115-165)” may allude to 2 Peter 2:1 in his work *Dialogue with Trypho*.¹⁶ In agreement with Bauckham, Kruger notes the possibility “that the *Apocalypse of Peter* (c. 110) was dependent upon 2 Peter.”¹⁷ Finally, Kruger pushes the date back into the first century with his notation of “1 Clement (c. 95-97).”¹⁸ Where Kruger and Bauckham diverge is at 3:4. Bauckham interprets “the fathers” to mean the apostolic fathers (and the first generation of believers), thus signaling 2 Peter comes from a post-apostolic age.¹⁹ By contrast, Kruger notes that this is not necessarily the correct interpretation because “nowhere in the NT or in the Apostolic Fathers is οἱ πατέρες [, the fathers.] used to refer to Christian ‘Fathers,’ but is consistently used to refer to Jewish patriarchs.”²⁰ Thus, a fundamental piece of evidence in Bauckham’s dating loses its power.²¹ Bauckham also states that Jude (either a source

Hermas (c. AD 80-100). He states, “these three works are 2 Peter’s closest relatives in the early church,” 150.

¹¹ Ibid., 150.

¹² Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, 158.

¹³ For much of what follows, I am indebted to M. Kruger, “The Authenticity of 2 Peter,” *JETS* 42, 645-71.

¹⁴ Ibid., 652.

¹⁵ Ibid., 653.

¹⁶ Ibid., 654.

¹⁷ Ibid.

¹⁸ Ibid.

¹⁹ R. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, 158. Peter is believed to have died somewhere from AD 60-8. See T. Schreiner, *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, 276. Bauckham believes one can be confident it is “in AD 64 or 65.” See R. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, 159.

²⁰ M. Kruger, “The Authenticity of 2 Peter,” 665.

²¹ Bauckham admits that the interpretation of “Fathers” as OT fathers has “the weight of usage,” R. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, 290.

for 2 Peter or a book which used 2 Peter as a source) may be dated to the AD 50s. If Bauckham is correct in saying that 2 Peter is connected with *1 Clem.*, *2 Clem.*, and the *Shepherd of Hermas* and that Jude was written in the AD 50s, but Kruger is right about how 3:4 ought to be interpreted, then we are no longer required to say that the book must be post-apostolic and therefore the claim of Petrine authorship has more plausibility than is often acknowledge.²²

Early Reception into the NT Canon

It must be stated that some in the early church doubted Petrine authorship. R. Bauckham writes, “Evidently 2 Peter was known throughout the second century, at least in some circles, but not widely used.”²³ He states that the churches that had the letter may have known that Peter did not write it and consequently viewed it as being in the same category as the rest of the pseudo-Petrine works.²⁴ This could explain the lack of widespread circulation.²⁵ Bauckham concludes by stating that the letter was gradually accepted, and Jerome’s firm stamp of approval probably helped its case.²⁶ Thus its attestation in the early church is clearly weak.

Kruger, as stated above, notes those who acknowledge its canonicity: Origen (c. AD 254; who used it, calling it Scripture, though he had some doubts about its authorship), Athanasius (c. AD 373), Gregory of Nazianzus (c. AD 390), Jerome (c. AD 420), and Augustine (c. AD 430).²⁷ Notably, Jerome believed that the different linguistic

²² Ibid., 13. Bauckham’s view restricts him to a window that is post-apostolic but pre-second century. However, if 3:4 is as Kruger states, the window may be more like AD 50-90.

²³ Ibid., 163.

²⁴ Ibid.

²⁵ Ibid., 162-3.

²⁶ Ibid., 163.

²⁷ For the full discussion of 2 Peter and Church Fathers, see M. Kruger, “The Authenticity of Peter,” 649-51. See also B. Warfield, “The Canonicity of Second Peter,” *Southern Presbyterian Review* 33, no. 1 (January 1881): 45-75 (54-64). The dates of deaths are supplied by K. Aland in K. Aland et al., eds., *The Greek New Testament*, 3rd ed. (Stuttgart: United Bible Societies, 1975), xxxvii-ix. Here are the citations for each of these Church Fathers: Origen, *Homilies on Joshua*, Hom. 7.1, trans. Barbara J. Bruce, *Ancient Christian Writers* 71 (New York: Paulist Press, 2002), 74,

styles of 1 and 2 Peter were due to “different amanuenses” (i.e., different secretaries).²⁸ Kruger says, “After Jerome’s time, there were no further doubts concerning 2 Peter’s place in the NT canon.”²⁹ While 2 Peter is absent from some canonical lists such as “the Muratorian Fragment (c. 180),” Kruger says that this does not mean it was absent due to rejection.³⁰ The earliest papyrus containing 2 Peter is $\mathfrak{P}^{72}$ (found within the Miscellaneous Codex): c. AD 250-300.³¹ Interestingly, this codex contains 1 and 2 Peter, Jude, Psalm 33 and 34 (LXX), and other books, thus suggesting a high view of 1 and 2 Peter.³² It is also included in “Codex Sinaiticus (4th century), Codex Vaticanus (4th century), and Codex Alexandrinus (5th century).”³³ Ultimately, 2 Peter was accepted into the canon based on the belief that Peter wrote it.³⁴ Kruger makes a helpful point: the letter was accepted as Petrine despite its early controversy and the presence of pseudo-Petrine literature; and we ought

https://books.google.com/books?id=Yq6reMY6KMUC&pg=PA74&source=gbs_toc_r&cad=1#v=onepage&q&f=false; Athanasius of Alexandria, “Festal Letter 39,” *Early Church Texts*, accessed April 10, 2026, https://earlychurchtexts.com/public/athanasius_39th_festal_letter.htm; Gregory of Nazianzus, “Concerning the Genuine Books of Divinely Inspired Scripture,” *Bible Research*, accessed April 10, 2026, <https://www.bible-researcher.com/gregory.html>; Jerome, *Epistula 120 (Ad Hedibiam)*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., vol. 6, trans. W. H. Fremantle (New York: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1893), accessed April 9, 2026, https://www.tertullian.org/fathers/jerome_hedibia_2_trans.htm; and Augustine, *On the Spirit and the Letter (De spiritu et littera)*, chap. 52. In *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, vol. 5. Translated by Peter Holmes and Robert Ernest Wallis. Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1887. New Advent, <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/1502.htm>.

²⁸ Ibid., 650. For a discussion of the linguistic differences and similarities, see R. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, 143-7; and M. Kruger, “The Authenticity of 2 Peter,” 656-61. For Jerome’s mention of two interpreters for 1 and 2 Peter, respectively, see Jerome, *Epistula 120 (Ad Hedibiam)*. It can be found under question #11.

²⁹ Ibid.

³⁰ Ibid.

³¹ For a detailed discussion of the significance of this manuscript, see P. Strickland, “The Curious Case of $\mathfrak{P}^{72}$: What an Ancient Manuscript Can Tell Us about the Epistles of Peter and Jude,” *JETS* 57, no. 4 (December 2014): 781-91. The dating is found on p. 784.

³² Strickland, in *ibid.*, states that, in addition to this Miscellaneous Codex, the community who had $\mathfrak{P}^{72}$ also had a “third century copy of 1 Peter, written in Sahidic Coptic” and “Psalms 33 and 34 were probably included in the Miscellaneous Codex because of the use of those psalms in 1 Peter...[and] the decision to include Melito’s *Paschal Homily*...is probably largely due to Melito’s literary dependence upon 1 Peter,” 789. It appears, then, that the community who owned the Miscellaneous Codex may have seen the Petrine tradition, including 2 Peter, as *authoritative texts* in the middle third to beginning of the fourth century, the time during, or after, Origen’s lifetime.

³³ M. Kruger, “The Authenticity of 2 Peter,” 651.

³⁴ T. Schreiner, *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, 264.

to at the least acknowledge that this may be evidence that the letter is from Peter.³⁵

Analysis and Conclusion

In my research, I found both sides of the argument for and against Petrine authorship to provide helpful information to the discussion. However, I found the pro-Petrine arguments sufficient to challenge the conclusion that Peter did not write it. From the dating of the letter, it seems that it was probably written in the first century, perhaps reaching early enough for Peter to have been the author.³⁶ From the Church Fathers, it is clear that some questioned the letter but ultimately accepted it as coming from Peter. There is more to discuss, such as the internal evidence; however, based on the external evidence, it seems plausible to me that Peter wrote 2 Peter and that it therefore holds its rightful place in the NT canon right after 1 Peter, his first canonical letter.

³⁵ M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," 651. He also writes, "Is it so easy to dismiss the conclusions of Origen, Cyril of Jerusalem, Gregory Nazianzen, Ephiphanius, Athanasius, Augustine, Rufinus, Jerome, and the church councils of Laodicea, Hippo and Carthage?"

³⁶ It is questionable whether Peter wrote the letter with his own hand or whether he used a secretary. Jerome believed Peter used a secretary. See *Epistula 120*; also, this view is suggested as "quite possible" by T. Schreiner, *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, 265. Some scholars, such as B. Ehrman, question whether Peter would have even been capable of writing the letter, supposing that he was illiterate. See B. Ehrman, "But Could Peter Write Anything?" *YouTube* video, 42:44, posted 2024, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PshpCo28UpE>. For a counter discussion of ancient illiteracy, see P. Eddy and G. Boyd, *The Jesus Legend: A Case for the Historical Reliability of the Synoptic Jesus Tradition* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2007), 241-52 (249-50).

Dating

For discussion of the dating, see Excursus above. To summarize, it seems to me that the dating of the letter must have been before Peter died in c. 64-5 AD. Depending on if one believes Jude used 2 Peter or vice versa (see “Relationship with Jude” below) and if the dating of Jude is in the 50s AD, then the dating for 2 Peter would be sometime between c. 50-64/5 AD, probably closer to 60 AD.

Audience

Understanding who Peter wrote this letter to is a hard question to solve. However, there are some clues left in the letter as to who his audience might have been.

Destination

TEXT

Recipients

1. A Jewish Audience?

When evaluating if the audience of 2 Peter is Jewish, what jumps out is the clear use of the OT (e.g., 2 Peter 2:4-8, 15-16, 22; 3:2¹, 4², 5-6). These are simply the most obvious references as you read the letters. For more allusions, connections, and the like, see Excursus: *The Communication of 1 and 2 Peter*, under *The Use of OT* (p. 18ff). M. Harmon is right: “The frequently allusive manner in which 2 Peter...use[s] the OT assumes the reader is so familiar with those OT persons and events that even a name or a brief phrase is enough to evoke the entire OT context of that reference.”³ This seems to give weight to a Jewish audience.

Commented [JH1]: Make sure to cover this in 3:2

¹ It may be that the term “holy prophets” may be a reference to OT prophets. For more on this, see comments on the passage below.

² “The Fathers” seems to be a reference to the OT fathers. For more on this, see p. 40 and also footnote 21 there.

³ Matthew S. Harmon, “Jude and the Second Letter of Peter,” in *Dictionary of the New Testament Use of the Old Testament*, ed. G. K. Beale et al. (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2023), 415.

Another piece of evidence for a Jewish audience may be Gal 2:7-8 along with the narrative of Acts. Peter was distinguished as the apostle to the Jews. This would logically lead to assume that the work Peter was doing at the end of his life was the same as in the days of Acts, some 30 years before. However, there is still evidence for a Gentile audience.

2. *A Gentile Audience?*

It took me a long time before I read 1:1 carefully enough to see what it said: “To those who have received a faith of the same kind as ours.” NA28 cross references Acts 11:17, which says, “Therefore if God gave to them [the Gentiles; Cornelius and his household] *the same gift as He gave to us also after believing in the Lord Jesus Christ*, who was I that I could stand in God’s way?” (Italics added). In Acts 11:17, Peter (interesting) relays to the Jews in Jerusalem that God has revealed that the Gentiles are able to be saved. The way God revealed this was in a dream and the Holy Spirit falling upon Cornelius and his household in Acts 10 (see 10:44). Peter comments in 11:17 that God had given the Gentiles “the same gift” (the Holy Spirit) as He had given to the apostles (and Jews?). So, does Acts 11:17 shed light on the audience referred to in 2 Peter 1:1?

Richard Bauckham picks up on this connection and comments:

“This has been understood either as a comparison between Jewish Christians, of whom Peter is one, and the Gentile Christian readers (cf. Peter’s words in Acts 11:17; 15:9, 11) (so Plumptre, Mayor, Boobyer, Leaney; Hanse in *TDNT* 4, 2), or as a comparison between the apostles, of whom Peter is one, and the readers, who are not apostles (so Spitta, Lumby, James, Moffatt, Reicke, Spicq; Zahn, *Introduction*, 206–7; Stählin in *TDNT* 3, 349). The latter is more probable because there is no other trace of the Jewish-Gentile issue in this letter, and

because in that case the first person plural is being used in the same sense as later in the chapter (vv 16–18)."⁴

So, in Bauckham's understanding, if there is a connection with Acts 11:17 (and also helpful, Acts 15:11), the understanding of 2 Peter 1 would be Jewish Christians exhorting Gentile Christians. Notice the pronouns in chapter 1: "Our," "Us," "We," and "You." In 1:1-4a it is "Our" and "Us." In 1:4b-15 it is "You." In 1:16-19 it is "We" and "You."

It seems clear to me (and Bauckham) that in 1:16-18, the two groups being mentioned are "We" apostles and "You" Christians. However, is that what is meant in 1:1-15?

According to Bauckham, the view that 1:1-15 is apostles and Christians (generally) is the most likely. This seems reasonable to me as well. However, it is interesting what Peter says in 1:4: "having escaped the corruption that is in the world by lust." In one sense that would be true of Jews, but the statement to me seems to be a comment that would be more applicable to the Gentiles, who would have *literally* come out of the world. Even if Bauckham is right that the audience is both Jews and Gentiles, it seems to me that there is a special emphasis on the Gentile audience of the letter.

As for Gal 2:7-8 and Acts? Notice Gal 2:7. Paul is noted as the apostle to the Gentiles, who is also mentioned in 2 Peter 3:15-16. Peter says that Paul "wrote to you" (3:15). Paul often wrote to churches that were made up of both Jews and Gentiles. If 2 Peter was written to a specific church, then it seems logical to say that the audience is a mix of Jews and Gentiles. And Acts,

⁴ R. Bauckham, *2 Peter, Jude*, 167.

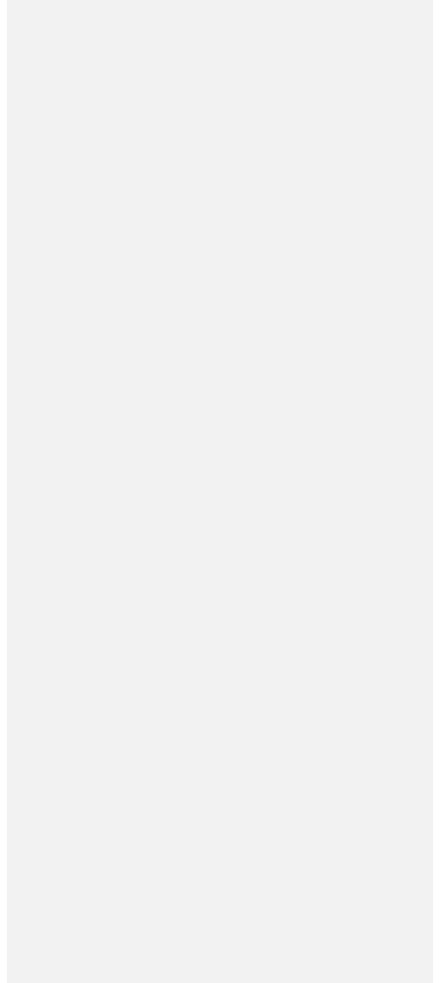
while Peter is the apostle to the Jews, it was he who first taught the Gospel to the Gentiles (Acts 10).

When all of this is examined, it seems that the audience Peter wrote to was probably a mixed group with special focus on the Gentiles in some sections and the Jews with their Scriptures in others.

2 Peter

1:1-

Text



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